Rashidov and his team were already in Havana. Alekseev asked Raúl Castro for an urgent meeting with his brother, and the very same evening Fidel met with his guests of honor. Events were moving at ever increasing speed.[17]

Missiles, not economic aid, now topped the agenda of the Soviet-Cuban meeting. Rashidov, the head of the delegation, spoke little, and most of the talking on the Soviet side was done by Biriuzov. The Cubans were taking notes—the first time that Alekseev, who now doubled as an interpreter, had ever seen them do so. Biriuzov began by expressing Soviet concern over the growing threat of an American invasion and asked Castro what could be done to avert it. Castro, knowing that something big was being considered, did not ask for additional military support but went directly for the ultimate prize: he had long wanted an agreement with the USSR that would give Cuba a guarantee of Soviet protection in the event of an American invasion. He had brought Cuba into the socialist camp and wanted an agreement like the one concluded by the Soviets with the Warsaw Pact in Eastern Europe, or the equivalent of article 5 of the NATO Charter—an attack on one member meant an attack on all. “Well,” Castro recalled having said many years later, “if the United States were to understand that an invasion of Cuba would mean war with the Soviet Union, that would be the best way to keep it from invading Cuba.”[18]

Biriuzov either did not understand the hint or decided not to take it. He made use of Castro’s comment to sell his own solution to the problem—missiles. “But specifically how?” asked Biriuzov with reference to Castro’s suggestion that the United States should be given to understand that an attack on Cuba would mean war with the Soviet Union. “Something concrete must be done to indicate that,” continued Biriuzov. According to Alekseev, Biriuzov declared that “the government of the USSR is prepared to help Cuba strengthen its defensive capability by all possible means, up to considering the question of installing intermediate-range missiles on its territory if our Cuban friends should find such a means of intimidating a potential aggressor useful.”[19]

As Castro remained silent, Alekseev sensed nervousness on the part of Biriuzov. “[H]e had been assigned the mission of proposing that the strategic missiles be installed, and he may have been afraid that we